How long have you…?: what Murphy does not tell you

Day 2 · Grammar beyond Murphy

Murphy first
Murphy red, Unit 18 (pages 46–47): *How long have you...?* Do **18.1, 18.2** in class, **18.3** at home. Unit 19 (pages 48–49): *for, since, ago*. Do **19.1** in class, **19.2, 19.3** at home. **19.5** is for fast students on Day 3.
This file adds five things the book does not explain.

1 · Which verbs go with "How long"?

Verbs of a **state** or a **situation**: **be** (been) · **live** · **know** · **have** · **work** · **study** · **wait**
*How long have you **known** him? How long has she **worked** here?*
Not with short actions: ✗ How long have you ~~come~~? → ✓ How long have you **been** here?

2 · The quick test: for or since?

for + a **length**: for three days · for an hour · for ages · for a long time · for all my life
since + a **starting point**: since Monday · since 9 o'clock · since 2019 · since last summer · since I was ten · since we arrived

Ask: "How many?" → for. "From when?" → since. And **ever since** = since then until now.

3 · Two ways to say the same

*I **haven't seen** him **for** a week. = It is a week **since** I saw him. = I last saw him a week **ago**.*

Notice: since + past simple in the second pattern.

4 · Short answers

How long have you lived here? → **For ten years.** / **Since 2015.** / **All my life.** / **Since I was born.**
How long have you been waiting? → **For an hour.** / **Since four.** / **Ages!**

5 · The Russian trap

«Я живу здесь пять лет» → *I **have lived** here **for** five years.* ✗ I live here five years. ✗ I live here ~~since five years~~.
«Я знаю его с 2010 года» → *I **have known** him **since** 2010.* ✗ I know him since 2010.

In Russian the verb stays in the present. In English the situation started in the past and goes on now: present perfect.

Practice

Day 2 · Practice 1

What to do: Exercises 1–2 in class, alone, then check. Exercise 3: the class translates aloud, one sentence each.

1 for or since? Write the word

1. We have lived on this island ____ 2015.
2. I have known my best friend ____ ten years.
3. She has been ill ____ Monday.
4. They have been on the beach ____ two hours.
5. He has worked here ____ a long time.
6. I have wanted a dog ____ I was five.
7. It has rained ____ the morning.
8. We have been friends ____ ages.

2 Make questions with How long...? and answer about YOU

1. (you / live in your house) ____
2. (you / study English) ____
3. (you / know your best friend) ____
4. (you / be in this room) ____
5. (your parents / live in this city) ____
6. (you / have your phone) ____

3 Translate into English

1. Я живу на острове десять лет.

2. Мы знакомы с 2018 года.

3. Он болен с понедельника.

4. Сколько времени вы здесь работаете?

5. Они ждут уже два часа.

6. Я не видел его целую неделю.

7. Она живёт здесь всю жизнь.

Practice 2

Day 2 · Practice 2

What to do: Alone, then read your sentences aloud.

4 Interview a partner: How long...?

Ask 6 questions: *How long have you lived in this city? How long have you studied here? How long have you had your phone? How long have you known your best friend?...* Write the answers in full sentences with for or since.

5 Complete the text: present perfect or present simple

My grandfather (1 live) _____ on a small island for forty years. He (2 be) _____ a fisherman since he was fifteen. He (3 know) _____ every rock and every wave. "I (4 not / leave) _____ the island for ten years," he says. "Why should I? I (5 love) _____ it." He (6 have) _____ the same boat since 1995, and he (7 fix) _____ it many times. How long (8 you / know) _____ a person like that? I (9 visit) _____ him every summer since I was six, and I (10 not / see) _____ a better place.

Answers · Day 2 grammar

For the teacher

1 since · for · since · for · for · since · since · for

2 Own answers: How long have you lived in your house? How long have you studied English? … with for / since.

3 I have lived on the island for ten years. · We have known each other since 2018. · He has been ill since Monday. · How long have you worked here? · They have been waiting for two hours. · I haven’t seen him for a whole week. · She has lived here all her life.

4 Own answers.

5 has lived · has been · knows · haven’t left · love · has had · has fixed · have you known · have visited · haven’t seen